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Interview Preparation Guide

Staff Security Engineer - Identity & Access Management

Overview

Congratulations on making it to the final virtual interview rounds. This guide outlines the structure, expectations, and preparation tips to help you succeed. Each interview is **60 minutes** and focuses on a different competency area.

*Required Equipment:

- A working computer or laptop with camera and internet access

Hiring Manager Session

This will be with the hiring manager who will be able to provide you with information on the different projects, engineering team culture, challenges, etc. They will be asking you about your career history, your job search (why you're looking, why is LinkedIn interesting, what technologies are you interested in), and an overview of interesting projects you worked on, and your involvement in these projects. They will also evaluate your thinking and problem-solving abilities: how do you figure out problems, develop solutions and alternatives, what is your decision-making process, your organizational fit, and your motivations.

System Design

Be prepared to discuss how you would design secure, scalable, and privacy-conscious platform services that operate at LinkedIn scale. Focus less on specific technologies and more on the tradeoffs, threat models, and architectural decisions involved in building security-sensitive systems. Be ready to explain how you would identify and mitigate common and advanced attack vectors, protect user privacy, validate and process untrusted data safely, secure service-to-service interactions, and apply Zero Trust principles across distributed systems.

We're also assessing your ability to demonstrate a balanced understanding of application security, infrastructure security, reliability, privacy, and operational considerations while articulating why particular design choices reduce risk.

Interviewers will also look for depth in areas such as isolation boundaries, trust assumptions, authentication and authorization models, secure handling of third-party dependencies, migration strategies for legacy systems, and how security controls can be implemented.

Craft Excellence

This module will assess your ability to maintain high quality within your craft in addition to upholding that value within an engineering work culture. Various areas will be assessed, including how as a Tech Lead you:

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- Hold yourself and your work to a high quality bar (i.e. show maturity around testing, care for performance, site speed, etc.)
- Leverage or build outputs beyond the scope of yourself or your team.
- Review others' work (including but not limited to code reviews).
- Are willing to share knowledge with proven experience mentoring/teaching to ensure high quality, testability, and so on.
- Think from a product point of view, and the pivots you may have taken to overcome system/product limitations.
- Create opportunities for junior engineers to design and implement parts of the solution.

Additional links to get a better understanding of LinkedIn's culture around Craftsmanship:

- What is Craftsmanship and Why is it Important?
- Leadership, Craftsmanship, and Execution

Staff Coding

Conducted via CodePad, this module will involve advanced analytical thinking, algorithmic skill, and problem solving ability. The problems will include coding with more advanced algorithmic and data structure complexity, where the overall runtime and scalability of the solutions will be a bit more important than the coding cleanliness; less focus on the actual code that comes out and could even involve (but not limited to) code reviews. The objective will be to create an extensible and scalable solution.

Example Question: Find Palindromes

Problem: Implement the following interface:
public interface PalindromeFinder {
/*
* Returns the set of all subsequences of s which are palindromes.
* For example, given the string "abcbrta", you should return "a", "abba", "abcba", "aca", "bcb", "aba", etc.
*/ public Set<String> findPalindromes(String s);
}
Sample input:
abqwerba -> [aba, bqb, e, abba, b, awa, a, abeba, bwb, abba, w, aqa, aea, r, abrba, q, beb, ara, brb, abba, aa, bb]

Example follow-ups: Consider an approach that favors another variable than the one you ended up on. Rather than returning the set, return an iterator over the set (so, each call to next() returns a new palindrome). Use only O('n) space

Staff Software Design & Architecture

This module will focus on Architecture and Design. In this discussion, you'll be asked to think through a large-scale identity modernization effort involving enterprise and production systems. Be prepared to explain how you would approach transforming a complex IAM ecosystem while maintaining reliability, security, and operational continuity. The conversation will focus on architectural trade-offs, establishing clear sources of

authority, reducing technical debt, designing phased migration strategies, and balancing identity governance, authentication, and authorization requirements across interconnected platforms.

Strong candidates typically demonstrate a structured approach, ask thoughtful clarifying questions, consider real-world constraints, and clearly communicate how they would drive an incremental transformation without disrupting critical business or production services.

Additional Resources:

- LeetCode
- TopCoder
- HackerRank - Data Structures
- HackerRank - Algorithms
- InterviewBit
- DSA Tutorials

Additional Information:

- LinkedIn Engineering
- Data @ LinkedIn
- LinkedIn Culture and Values
- Engineering Blog
- LinkedIn Engineering Youtube Channel
- LinkedIn & Microsoft changing the way the world works

Please also have some questions to ask the interviewers (interview us too!). This not only shows that you are interested, but it will help you make sure this is the right place for you.

If you have any questions prior to your interviews, please don't hesitate to reach out!

Good luck with your interview!